

11 September 2026

Dear Editor,

Please consider our manuscript, “Citation Faithfulness in Open-Weight Retrieval-Augmented Generation,” for publication in your journal.

The manuscript studies whether generated citations reflect the evidence that influenced an answer, rather than only whether the cited text supports the final claim. We evaluate this question through controlled post-rationalization interventions on Natural Questions and KILT Wikipedia, a ConflictBank validation experiment, a focused activation-patching study on PopQA, and linear probes of hidden states across three open-weight instruction-tuned models.

The results provide a measured account of citation faithfulness. Forged documents are cited more often when they are relevant or already plausible in the citation context. Supplied context also changes model answers in knowledge-conflict cases. The mechanistic intervention did not control citation behavior during full generation, while hidden-state probes provided a predictive signal associated with the behavioral label. We report these positive and negative findings together and distinguish prediction from causal evidence throughout the manuscript.

This work is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration elsewhere. All authors have reviewed and approved the manuscript and agree with its submission. The authors declare no competing interests.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Jeremiah O. Abimbola

Corresponding author

Faculty of Automatic Control, Electronics and Computer Science

Silesian University of Technology, Gliwice, Poland

jeremiah.abimbola@polsl.pl